CARRIER SELECTION

Carrier Vetting & Onboarding.

Verify the carrier. Follow the policy. Leave a decision record you can explain.



LUIS URIBE

Practical skills. Better freight businesses.

VERIFY / DOCUMENT / RECHECK

01 / START HERE

A process you can explain.

What this guide helps you do

A carrier can be real, authorized and willing to take your load without being the right choice for that shipment. Use this guide to organize the questions, verify the answers and decide what still needs review.

The goal is a repeatable process that your team can actually follow under time pressure. Fast onboarding comes from preparation and clear responsibilities, not skipping unresolved checks.

How to use the guide

Start with the legal context, six-check workflow and information sources. Then work through identity, safety, insurance and the approval decision.

Use the interview and load-conversation scripts before completing the shipment-specific release check. Keep a decision record, manage material changes and adopt a written policy your team can follow.

The working tools near the end add a carrier profile, the original rate-negotiation example, an event log, a policy-adherence check and a load-release record. Primary sources follow those tools.

Scope and limits

This is an educational guide for U.S. freight brokerage operations. Suggested controls are not a universal legal standard, a guarantee against fraud or a substitute for shipment-specific requirements. Have transportation counsel and your insurance adviser review the policy you adopt.

Legal and source review date: October 19, 2026. Registration systems and available data change; check the linked official sources when using this guide.

> **KEEP IN MIND**
>
> Network approval and load approval are separate decisions. An approved carrier still needs to be suitable and eligible for the next shipment.

02 / THE LEGAL CONTEXT

What Montgomery changes.

The decision

On May 14, 2026, the U.S. Supreme Court unanimously decided Montgomery v. Caribe Transport II, LLC, No. 24-1238. It held that the FAAAA safety exception preserves the negligent-hiring claim at issue against the freight broker. The Court reversed and remanded. [1]

What it did not decide

The decision did not find the broker negligent, determine damages, establish a mandatory carrier-vetting checklist or make a broker automatically liable whenever a carrier crashes. The underlying liability issues require further proceedings under applicable law. [1]

The operating lesson

Our recommendation: make carrier selection a reasoned decision, supported by the information available when you made it. An active registration, a signed agreement and a favorable software indicator each answer only part of the question.

When information raises a material concern, identify it, investigate it and record the disposition. A file containing screenshots is incomplete if nobody explains what the concerning information meant for the shipment.

Keep the distinction clear

The legal holding above comes from the Court. The verification, escalation and documentation practices in the following pages are recommended brokerage procedures. Do not label them “Montgomery-compliant” or promise that following them prevents liability.

> **KEEP IN MIND**
>
> Ask: What did we know, what did we investigate, and why did the person with approval authority decide to proceed?

03 / THE WORKFLOW

Six checks. One accountable decision.

01 / Identity

Confirm the legal entity, USDOT identifier and the authority of the person arranging the load. Resolve discrepancies between the contact, documents and official records.

02 / Operating status

Check the registration and authority applicable to the movement. Distinguish an actual restriction from a missing, stale or conflicting database record.

03 / Safety information

Review the available official rating and relevant operating history in context. Identify concerns that need escalation rather than treating a single score as an answer.

04 / Insurance

Verify the carrier, dates, limits and coverage relevant to the shipment. Confirm material questions with an independently verified agent or insurer.

05 / Shipment fit

Confirm equipment, commodity, handling, appointments and timing. Verify specialized capabilities where the shipment requires them.

06 / Agreement and release

Complete the applicable agreement and rate confirmation. Record approval, reviewer and restrictions. Give the facility the expected carrier details and a process for reporting a mismatch.

> **KEEP IN MIND**
>
> The booking employee gathers the facts. The designated reviewer resolves exceptions. Nobody overrides a legal prohibition to save a load.

04 / INFORMATION SOURCES

Know which record you are reading.

Registration and authority: Motus

FMCSA directs users to Motus for newer registration activity. Its guidance states that activity after May 18, 2026 should be checked through Motus; legacy Licensing & Insurance does not reflect new Motus filings. Do not use an older lookup as your only source for current status. [2, 3]

Company information: SAFER

Use the Company Snapshot for identification and the available safety-rating, inspection, out-of-service and crash information. Record the relevant dates. A USDOT identification record and operating authority are different things. [4]

Safety performance: SMS

SMS provides performance information used for agency prioritization. It is not a federal safety-fitness rating. Review its limitations before interpreting an indicator or percentile. [5]

When records disagree

Capture the conflicting results and dates, then hold the affected decision while the designated reviewer verifies the current position with FMCSA or another appropriate primary source. Do not infer either authorization or fraud from a missing record alone.

Third-party tools can help collect and monitor information. Save the underlying finding and its date, not only the tool’s green or red status. Investigate stale feeds and conflicting results.

Evidence to keep

Record the source, identifier searched, retrieval time, data date if shown, result and any unresolved question. Keep enough context that another reviewer can understand what you relied on.

05 / IDENTITY

Verify who is actually accepting the load.

Start with the business

Obtain the legal name, USDOT number, relevant authority details, dispatcher name and contact information. Compare the information across the company record, packet and booking conversation.

FMCSA recommends calling the company number listed in SAFER when the supplied number differs, and warns that documents, including insurance certificates, can be fraudulent. [6]

Use independent contact verification

Do not use caller ID or a matching area code as proof. Confirm the person's role through an independently established company contact. A confirmation email from the same unverified person is not independent evidence.

Investigate changed contact details, unexplained document inconsistencies and requests to switch payment or delivery instructions. Record how each discrepancy was resolved. A change may be legitimate; it still needs verification.

Connect the booking to pickup

Agree in advance how the facility will check the expected carrier and identify discrepancies. FMCSA recommends matching the arriving truck's name and identifiers with the contracted carrier and recording vehicle details. [6]

Hold release when a material mismatch remains unresolved. Verify a substitution through established contacts rather than accepting a last-minute message at face value.

Keep the check evidence-based

A different area code, small fleet or new relationship is not proof of fraud. Focus on authenticated identity, consistent information and the ability to perform the specific movement.

> **KEEP IN MIND**
>
> The carrier on the paperwork, the party accepting the load and the carrier arriving for pickup should form a traceable, explained chain.

06 / SAFETY REVIEW

Read the history. Investigate the concern.

Separate ratings from performance data

Read the formal safety rating and its date, if a rating exists. “Not rated” is not the same as a satisfactory rating. A conditional rating requires a different review from an out-of-service order. Do not treat these labels as interchangeable. [4, 5, 7]

Review the available details

Consider relevant inspection findings, out-of-service information and crash records with their dates and sample sizes. Look for the facts behind an indicator. Small denominators and old records need context.

Do not assume a crash count establishes fault. Do not create a universal “acceptable CSA score.” FMCSA cautions against drawing conclusions about overall safety solely from SMS data. [5]

Ask for a specific response

Identify the finding you are concerned about. Ask what happened, what changed and what documentation supports the explanation. Compare the response with the original record and other available evidence.

If the concern remains material and unresolved, keep the carrier or shipment on hold for the person authorized to decide. Do not substitute a reassuring conversation for supporting evidence.

Set the rule before the urgent shipment

A proposed policy is to require designated safety or compliance review for conditional ratings and other defined material concerns. Counsel should review the triggers and permitted outcomes. A conditional rating is not, by itself, the same thing as a current prohibition on operation.

> **KEEP IN MIND**
>
> No rating does not mean no risk. A warning indicator does not, by itself, prove a carrier is unsafe. Document the investigation and decision.

07 / INSURANCE

Verify coverage for the actual movement.

Confirm the source

Obtain insurance documentation through an independently verified agent or insurer. Match the named insured to the carrier you are hiring. Investigate altered certificates, inconsistent names and unexplained contact details. FMCSA warns that certificates can be fraudulent. [6]

Ask the shipment questions

Confirm policy dates, relevant limits, deductibles and material exclusions. Ask whether the commodity, equipment, territory and services involved create a coverage issue. Route uncertain policy interpretation to your insurance adviser.

Check the expected shipment period, not just the day the packet arrived. Clarify any cancellation or renewal issue before release. Do not assume a certificate explains every condition or guarantees a claim will be paid.

Keep different protections separate

Auto liability, cargo coverage and the brokerage's own policies address different exposures. A federal filing does not answer every question about a particular cargo movement. A carrier agreement does not replace insurance verification.

Record what was confirmed

Keep the document, the independently sourced contact, the date and the substance of the confirmation. Identify who evaluated any exception and the basis for the outcome.

Use company-approved coverage requirements that reflect the freight, contracts and applicable rules. This guide does not prescribe one dollar limit as suitable for every shipment.

> **KEEP IN MIND**
>
> Insurance verification is one part of carrier selection. It does not resolve an unsafe operating condition or an identity mismatch.

08 / DECISION RULES

Approve, hold or decline.

APPROVE / Within delegated authority

Proceed only when the relevant checks are complete, the carrier meets the adopted policy and shipment requirements, and material concerns have been resolved. Record who approved what, any restrictions and the next review trigger.

HOLD / More information or review needed

Examples: conflicting official records; unverified identity; unclear insurance applicability; a material safety concern; or a substitution that has not been authenticated.

A hold is not an accusation. State what evidence is missing, who owns the follow-up and who can decide the outcome. Obtain another qualified option if the issue cannot be resolved in time.

DECLINE OR BLOCK / Do not tender

Do not tender a movement when a verified prohibition or missing required authorization prevents it. An employee exception cannot make unlawful operation permissible.

Company policy may also require declining a carrier that does not meet its standards or cannot resolve a material concern. Record whether the reason is a legal restriction, a company-policy decision or insufficient verified information.

Control exceptions

Name the roles allowed to consider policy exceptions, the evidence required and any expiry or load limitation. Sales pressure, a low rate or prior use is not an approval rationale.

Do not authorize an exception merely because someone checked a box. Record the actual reason and supporting facts; never backdate or fabricate a review.

> **KEEP IN MIND**
>
> These categories are a proposed operating framework. Have counsel review the detailed triggers and rules before adoption.

09 / THE INTERVIEW

Ask. Verify. Follow up.

Open the conversation

Broker: “What is your legal company name and USDOT number? What is your name and role with the carrier?”

Broker: “I will verify the company details and the contact authorized to accept this load before we finish setup.”

Confirm capability

Broker: “Where is the available truck, what equipment is it, and can you meet these pickup and delivery requirements?”

Broker: “Who will actually perform the transportation? Tell me about any intended substitution or involvement of another carrier before we proceed.”

Resolve a fleet discrepancy

Broker: “Your current fleet description differs from the record I am viewing. What does each number include, when was the record updated, and what supports the current information?”

Do not use a fixed “within five trucks” test. FMCSA describes periodic MCS-150 updates and delays before changes appear in SMS. Evaluate the record date and explanation. [8]

Address a safety concern

Broker: “I am reviewing [specific finding and date]. What was the issue, what corrective action was taken, and what supporting information can our reviewer examine?”

If unresolved: “We need our designated reviewer to resolve this before I can authorize the shipment.”

Close with a defined next step

Broker: “Please have your verified insurance contact provide the required information. I will send our agreement and confirm the remaining items. Setup is complete only when our approval process is finished.”

10 / THE LOAD CONVERSATION

Be clear about the load and the rate.

Start with availability

Broker: “I am calling from [brokerage] about your truck in [city]. Is it still available?”

Carrier: “Yes.”

Broker: “We have a pickup on [date] in [city/state], delivering to [city/state] on [date or appointment]. Does that fit your equipment and schedule?”

Describe the real shipment

Broker: “It is [pickup/drop count], [commodity], packaged in [packaging], weighing [weight], with [equipment and handling requirements]. It is [hazardous/nonhazardous, if confirmed]. The pickup and delivery requirements are [details].”

Use only confirmed facts. Do not default to “no touch,” “nonhazardous” or a simple appointment when you have not checked.

Discuss the price honestly

Broker: “For that scope, the offered rate is [amount], with [agreed accessorial terms].”

Carrier: “Can you do better?”

Broker: “What rate would work for you?”

If you genuinely need approval: “I need to confirm that amount. I will come back with a clear answer.” Do not invent a customer conversation or approval limit.

Keep price separate from approval

Agreeing a rate does not complete carrier selection. Finish the outstanding checks and then issue the load confirmation under your process. Confirm the scope and written terms match what both parties accepted.

Give realistic timing and avoid pressuring a carrier to accept a schedule it cannot safely perform.

> **KEEP IN MIND**
>
> The negotiating examples are adaptable scripts, not promises of a rate outcome or shortcuts around verification.

11 / LOAD RELEASE

The shipment-specific check.

Carrier and contact

Confirm the approved legal entity, USDOT identifier, authorized dispatcher and verified communication channel. Record the person responsible for this load.

Shipment facts

Confirm commodity, packaging, piece count, dimensions and weight as applicable. Identify temperature control, hazardous materials, securement or other specialized requirements that need separate verification.

Equipment and timing

Confirm suitable equipment, pickup and delivery locations, operating hours, appointments, reference numbers, loading responsibilities and a feasible schedule. Escalate a stated inability to meet the requirements.

Current status and coverage

Apply the required pre-tender recheck. Confirm there is no unresolved status, identity, safety or coverage issue affecting this movement. Verify the approval remains valid for this scope.

Documents and changes

Reconcile the customer instructions, carrier agreement and rate confirmation. Record the agreed price and relevant accessorial terms. Reassess any material change instead of carrying approval forward automatically.

Pickup and exception instructions

Tell the facility which carrier is expected and who to contact if the arriving carrier differs. Establish the update channel, escalation contact and document-return process. Record the release decision.

> **KEEP IN MIND**
>
> This is a release reference, not a certification that every legal or shipper-specific requirement has been met.

12 / THE DECISION RECORD

Leave a record another person can follow.

Identify the decision

Record the legal carrier name, USDOT number, load or account reference, reviewer, decision time and the scope of approval. Separate network approval from load-specific release.

Preserve the evidence

Keep the official sources checked, retrieval times, available record dates, relevant results and supporting documents. Save the meaningful information, not just a link to a record that may later change.

Explain the concern and response

Write what was inconsistent or concerning, what questions were asked, who responded and what evidence was obtained. Record unresolved issues honestly. Separate observed facts from allegations or assumptions.

Explain the outcome

State approve, hold or decline and the factual basis. Record any policy exception, authorized approver, limits and review trigger. “Previously used” or “system approved” is not a complete explanation.

Keep records responsibly

Use a consistent storage location, access controls and a counsel-reviewed retention schedule. Limit unnecessary personal information. Do not invent a universal retention period from this guide.

If a serious incident or claim occurs, notify the designated contact and preserve relevant records under the applicable hold instructions. Do not overwrite the selection history or rewrite notes to make an earlier decision appear better.

> **KEEP IN MIND**
>
> A decision record documents the work actually performed. It does not replace the investigation or guarantee a legal defense.

13 / AFTER ONBOARDING

Approval needs a way to change.

Define the recheck points

Set an achievable pre-tender process and periodic review schedule. Assign owners for authority, coverage and material change alerts. Choose intervals with counsel, your insurance adviser and the operations team; do not publish a monitoring promise you cannot execute.

Act on material changes

Reassess a change in operating status, coverage, identity, ownership/contact information, relevant safety information or actual shipment performance. Reauthenticate unexpected substitutions and payment or destination changes.

Log the alert, action, owner and final disposition. A monitoring subscription does not complete the work if nobody resolves the notifications.

Handle interruptions without guessing

If a tool is unavailable or official records conflict, use the approved fallback and escalation process. Preserve the evidence of the outage or discrepancy. Do not silently substitute an old approval for a missing current check.

Respond to an incident

Address immediate safety needs through appropriate emergency channels. Notify the brokerage's designated incident lead, insurer and counsel as appropriate. Preserve the booking, verification and communication records.

Avoid speculative blame or unauthorized commitments. Follow verified instructions when coordinating cargo and keep factual communications with the parties involved.

Improve the process

Review recurring discrepancies and near misses. Update training and policy through a controlled process, with an effective date and a named owner. Keep the earlier versions and decision history intact.

14 / ADOPTING THE PROCESS

Make the policy realistic and consistent.

Set the operating boundaries

Define which freight, modes and territories the policy covers; who can approve carriers; who reviews concerns; and who can release a load. Specialized freight may need additional controls beyond this guide.

Decide the escalation rules

Have transportation counsel review conditional-rating treatment, material safety triggers, required authority, exception limits and the distinction between policy choices and legal prohibitions. Do not describe every flagged carrier as legally barred.

Align the agreements and insurance

Review customer promises, carrier agreements and your brokerage's coverage with qualified advisers. Avoid commitments to continuous monitoring or universal compliance that your actual process cannot support.

The carrier remains responsible for its operating obligations. Coordinate shipment requirements without directing unsafe conduct or treating a brokerage interview as a substitute for the carrier's driver-qualification and safety-management duties.

Train for the difficult moment

Employees should know how to pause a booking, explain the missing requirement and obtain review when a customer is waiting. Give them an escalation contact and a workable alternative-carrier process.

A short adoption review

Confirm: sources are current; the checks can be performed; each alert has an owner; exceptions are controlled; retention is defined; and the legal explanation has been reviewed. Version the policy and teach the team what changed.

> **KEEP IN MIND**
>
> Prepared as Freightskills educational material. Company-specific policy and legal review are still required before adopting these procedures.

WORKING TOOL / CARRIER RELATIONSHIPS

Make onboarding efficient and useful.

Preserve the original operating lesson

A slow, disorganized onboarding process can cost you an available truck and strain both carrier and customer relationships. Prepare the packet, assign a point of contact and explain what remains before approval.

A professional process also helps a carrier assess your brokerage. Follow up on missing items, keep communications clear and avoid making the carrier repeat information already received. Speed comes from a consistent process, not bypassing unresolved checks.

Keep the relationship details

In addition to the verified legal identity and approval record, capture the carrier's operating base, equipment, preferred lanes, truck availability and established contact details.

The original interview asks where the carrier likes to run. Keep that question: those preferences can help you identify future load opportunities. Verify shipment-specific capability each time.

After sending the carrier packet, confirm receipt through the established contact and follow up until the required items are returned. Receipt of an email alone is not independent identity verification.

Operating base / preferred lanes / equipment / verified contact

WORKING TOOL / ORIGINAL RATE EXAMPLE

Negotiate with a clear limit.

The original script's rate discussion is retained below as an illustrative negotiation. The amounts are examples, not a market-rate recommendation or a promised outcome.

Carrier: "Can you do rate + $300?"

Broker: "Right now I know I can go up to rate + $175. Would you be able to meet me there?"

Carrier: "Sure, let's do it."

Deliver the offer clearly

The original teaching emphasizes stating the offer with confidence instead of turning the rate into a hesitant question. Be clear about the actual load, service requirements and price.

Use an approval limit only when it is real. If you need to check an amount, say so and return with an accurate answer. Do not imply a customer discussion took place when it did not.

If the carrier asks shipment questions first, use your load-information checklist to answer them. Confirm the real pickup/drop count, handling, commodity, packaging and hazardous-material status rather than defaulting to the example.

After agreeing the rate, finish carrier approval and issue matching written terms before releasing the load.

Actual offered rate / authorized limit / agreed accessorial terms

WORKING TOOL / AUDITABLE EVENTS

Document the event and the decision.

Suggested event categories for your adopted policy. Capture the actual work performed, not a reconstructed checklist after a problem occurs.

Event	Evidence and outcome to record
Initial carrier review	Sources, retrieval times, record dates, findings, reviewer and approval scope.
Identity or contact discrepancy	Conflicting information, independent verification, who responded and how the issue was resolved.
Safety or insurance concern	Specific finding, supporting documents, questions asked, response and designated review.
Policy exception or override request	Policy/version, proposed deviation, authority to decide, rationale, limits, expiry and disposition.
Pre-tender and load release	Load requirements, recheck result, assigned carrier, unresolved items and release approver.
Substitution or material change	What changed, notification time, hold or recheck, authenticated instructions and final decision.
Monitoring alert or incident	Alert, owner, action, escalation, evidence preservation and closure.

ONE EVENT, ONE TRACEABLE RECORD

At minimum, identify the carrier/load, event time, actor, finding, evidence location, policy applied, action, decision authority and next step. Define required fields and retention in your company policy.

WORKING TOOL / EVENT LOG

A record another reviewer can follow

Carrier legal name / USDOT / load or account reference

Event / timestamp / employee recording it

Policy version / relevant requirement / source and evidence location

Finding / discrepancy / response and verification performed

Decision: approve, hold or decline / reason / authorized reviewer

Restrictions / exception expiry / next action / owner / review date

WORKING TOOL / POLICY ADHERENCE

A written policy must match the work.

Before a booking

Make the current approved policy accessible. Define the required checks, evidence, approval roles, escalation triggers, exception limits and recheck points.

Train employees on the policy and the specific steps they perform. A policy document is useful only when the team understands it and has a workable way to follow it.

When the policy is difficult to follow

Pause and escalate the affected decision. Record the issue and use the authorized fallback or exception process. Do not silently skip a check because the load is urgent.

Distinguish a company-policy exception from a legal prohibition. No internal approval can authorize a prohibited movement.

Check adherence in practice

Review a sample of completed files against the policy version in force at the time. Compare the required steps with the evidence and timestamps in the file.

Assign corrective actions when a step was missed. If the policy is unworkable, revise it through the designated approval process, give it an effective date and train the team. Preserve the earlier policy and original decision record.

Policy owner / current version / team training record

File review finding / corrective action / owner / due date

WORKING TOOL / LOAD INFORMATION

Confirm the shipment before release.

Carrier / dispatcher / verified channel / truck identification

Pickup and delivery / dates / hours / appointments / references

Commodity / packaging / pieces / dimensions / weight

Equipment / temperature / hazardous materials / handling requirements

Rate / accessorials / agreement / signed rate confirmation

Status and coverage check / outstanding issues / release approver

PRIMARY SOURCES

Read the source. Check the date.

The revised guide's source review date is October 19, 2026. The Montgomery opinion and Motus filing guidance were rechecked for this design edition on October 25, 2026. Other original source references are retained; check live records when using the guide.

[1] U.S. Supreme Court: Montgomery v. Caribe Transport II, LLC

May 14, 2026. No. 24-1238. Majority opinion; preemption holding and disposition.

[2] FMCSA: What can I do in Motus?

Registration guidance on newer filings and record activity.

[3] FMCSA: Registration status FAQs

Legacy Licensing & Insurance limitations during the Motus transition.

[4] FMCSA: Company Safety Records

SAFER Company Snapshot and the information it provides.

[5] FMCSA: Safety Measurement System

SMS purpose, safety-rating distinction and interpretation limitations.

[6] FMCSA: Broker and Carrier Fraud and Identity Theft

Independent contact checks, document fraud and pickup identity guidance.

[7] FMCSA: Investigations by Safety Rating - definitions

Definitions of formal safety-rating categories.

[8] FMCSA: SMS Help Center

MCS-150 updates and delays before changes appear in SMS.

YOUR NEXT STEP / FREE COMMUNITY

Keep learning. Keep moving.

Join the free FreightSkills community on Skool.

Put this guide to work alongside people who understand the freight business. Bring your questions, share what you are learning, and keep building your skills.

01 **Guidance from Luis**

Ask questions and get input from Luis in community discussions.

02 **Support from other members**

Compare notes, exchange ideas, and learn from the challenges other freight professionals are working through.

03 **Stay current with new content**

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